

Pikachu Went to Space!

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Pikachu has been to space! On September 19, 2026, the European Space Agency, or ESA, shared that a Pikachu **plush** toy spent 67 days on the **International Space Station**.

The toy blasted off on April 11 on a Cygnus **cargo spacecraft**. It came back to Earth on June 17 on a SpaceX Dragon **cargo spacecraft**. While in space, Pikachu circled Earth about 1,040 times!

The trip was planned to kick off World Space Week, which runs from October 4 to 10. ESA made a special **exhibit** that mixes real space science with Pokémon. It started in Paris, France, and will visit places across Europe until April 2027.

Pokémon GO players can join in too. At some science and space museums in Europe, they can try special **raids** with Astronaut Pikachu.

"Inspiring future generations is a key part of ESA's mission," said ESA leader Josef Aschbacher.

Word Treasure

plush -- A plush toy is a soft, stuffed toy.

International Space Station -- The International Space Station is a big science lab that circles Earth with astronauts on board.

cargo spacecraft -- A cargo spacecraft carries supplies to space instead of people.

exhibit -- An exhibit is a display that people can visit and look at, often in a museum.

raids -- In Pokémon GO, raids are special battles where players team up to catch a Pokémon.

Background you need

The International Space Station is a lab in space where astronauts live and do science. Cargo spacecraft carry food, tools and experiments up to the station and bring things back. World Space Week is a celebration that helps people learn about space.

Break it down

WHO: The European Space Agency and a Pikachu plush toy

WHAT: Pikachu spent 67 days on the International Space Station

WHERE: The International Space Station and an exhibit traveling across Europe

WHY: To kick off World Space Week and get kids excited about space

Why it matters

Fun characters like Pikachu can make learning about space exciting for kids.

Test what you remember

1. How long did the Pikachu plush stay on the space station?

- ☐ (A) 67 days
- ☐ (B) 1 year
- ☐ (C) 2 hours
- ☐ (D) 7 days

2. Which group shared the news about Pikachu?

- ☐ (A) The European Space Agency
- ☐ (B) A toy store
- ☐ (C) A soccer team
- ☐ (D) A zoo

3. How did Pikachu come back to Earth?

- ☐ (A) It is still in space
- ☐ (B) On a SpaceX Dragon cargo spacecraft
- ☐ (C) On an airplane
- ☐ (D) By parachute alone

4. About how many times did Pikachu circle Earth?

- ☐ (A) About 1,040 times
- ☐ (B) About 67 times
- ☐ (C) About 1 million times
- ☐ (D) About 10 times

5. When is World Space Week this year?

- ☐ (A) April 11 to June 17
- ☐ (B) All summer
- ☐ (C) October 4 to 10
- ☐ (D) December 1 to 7

6. Where did the special exhibit start?

- ☐ (A) London, England
- ☐ (B) Tokyo, Japan
- ☐ (C) New York City
- ☐ (D) Paris, France

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):